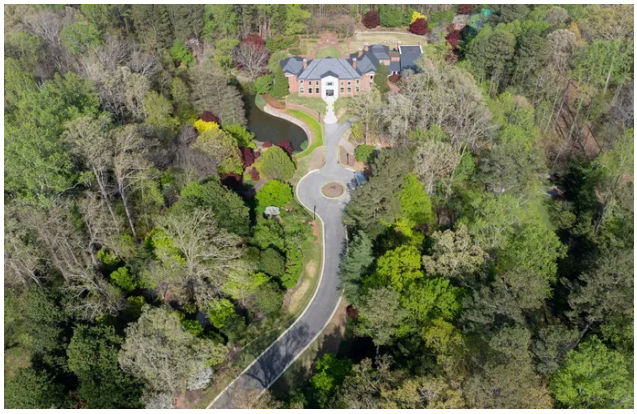
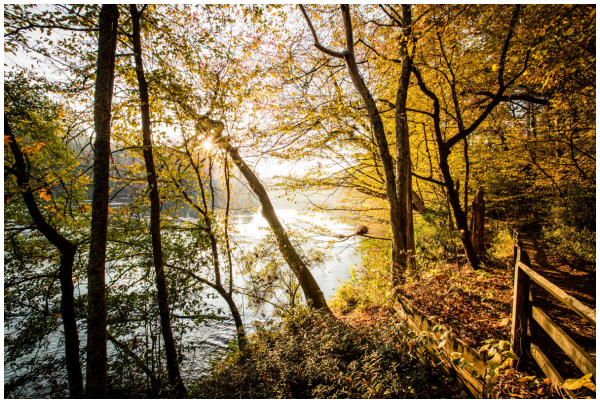
Background

A 2-gram trip of Penis Envy mushrooms brings strong effects without fully overwhelming the mind (a 'big trip' is about 3.5 grams, and smaller doses are around 0.5-1.5 grams.) Psilocybin affects the brain's serotonin system and loosens how thoughts and senses are organized. The brain's "default mode network," is relaxed, often making one feel a sense of everything feeling more connected and alive. Set and setting are crucial: calm spaces with good music or nature make the trip feel beautiful, while loud, chaotic environments can create anxiety. Visuals are usually not random images like with acid (ie: see a Lion), but patterns (walls ripple, colors glow, and geometric shapes appear if you focus.) Afterward, users often report lingering feelings of emotional clarity and renewed appreciation for life, lasting anywhere from days into one's life perspective thereafter. And research has consistently shown that psilocybin mushrooms are effective in reducing dependence on substances such as alcohol and marijuana, often helping individuals replace harmful patterns of frequent substance use with healthier, more intentional behaviors.

James is a sophomore at a liberal arts college in the northeast. He's been seeing a therapist on and off for the last 5 years, but still feels unfulfilled in his life. He was a perfect student in High school, but by sophomore year he is unsatisfied with his GPA and social life and is deliberating if he continues on a business major track. He's always had a strained relationship with his family, but even in college, he still has a room saved for him at home.

His two best friends from home never left town - a suburb on the outskirts of Atlanta. They began work locally straight out of high school. Over Winter Break, James comes home to hang out with his friends, and it turns out they have been experimenting with magic mushrooms throughout the year. They tell him about how positively impactful their experiences have been. They offer him to do a 2 gram trip of penis envy mushrooms, which they would join him on, taking around 3 grams as they are more familiar with the substance. James' friends show him a 3-minute youtube summary of 'what is a mushroom trip and how to prepare.' James has smoked weed and drunk alcohol a lot in college. He's never experimented beyond this but has been curious about trying mushrooms for a while as he has heard about the therapeutic benefits on his Instagram reels even though he knows 'bad trips' do sometimes occur. Case takes place at James' house while his parents are out of town and James is dog-sitting and his friends plan to sleepover. The house is located on the edge of the woods. (refer to images below.)

Before coming home, James was already aware of the potential benefits of psilocybin and had read a few studies about their recreational use. For example, he read one study that showed, in the vast majority of tested instances, family members testified that those who tried the mushrooms demonstrated better relationships with their family members afterward and seemed mentally better off. Now, as he deliberates joining his friends on the trip, he does some additional research and discusses with his friends about the best things to do during a mushroom trip - the leading suggestions, from online and his friends, include:

- Listen to your favorite music / psychedelic music
- Go into nature and walk barefoot
- Bring a journal with you / do audio recordings of your experience
- Be careful when looking at yourself in a mirror

Caveats:

1. A psilocybin trip can only be done at most every 3 weeks, as the psilocybin is still in the body and needs to be processed out. A first trip will never mimic the nature of subsequent trips because the feelings aren't novel.
2. The shrooms are pure and aren't laced, but your friends are supplying them.
3. If you don't do the trip, they will still do the shrooms at your house, as you invited them to sleep over.
4. Opp must defend not doing shrooms for the rest of college. If you dont do the trip now, you don't end up doing any shrooms later.

THBT it is in James's best interest to join his friends on the trip.
Framing

1. James' life is currently stagnant
2. He wants the trip to have a therapeutic aspect
3. He will be a good manager of it

Argument 1: The Experience of Tripping Itself Will Be Intrinsically Good

1. James is home and in the woods he grew up, this is a safe environment for him
    a. He is also with his dog, who his parents trust him to dog-sit, so his relationship with the dog is likely to be cement his sense of comfort and lowered anxiety
    b. His parents aren't home so he doesn't need to worry about any oversight by them
2. With friends, a good trip is assured because of their mutual investment in an enjoyable experience.
    a. Because this moment is novel for James, the significance of the trip is higher, while for them, their familiarity and incentive to have you enjoy your time is clear - they invited James to do it!
    b. They have done shrooms before so have more knowledge about how to maximize the trip in a proper way, and CARE about you having a good trip
        i. This is inclusive but not limited to
            1. Therapeutic conversations: deconstructing past memories
            2. Running around in the forest
            3. Meditating (even if not 'real' meditation)
            4. And this is most crucial: his friends will give him most say on the options for what to do with the trip. The trip is considered 'James trip' so any of his desires will be welcomed by his friends. This means james is not only comfortable, but able to engage with the positive experience without feeling limited or expected to behave a certain way
    c. The difference between shrooms and other substances like alcohol and weed is significant. While he enjoys those substances, the novel feeling to the shrooms reinforces his euphoric interpretation of the altered mind state.
3. The solo aspect of the trip
    a. After his research and deliberation, James has coherent intentions for his experience to the extent that a devoted time of introspection will allow him to reconcile any past issues but also confront ones in front of him - he can revisit the themes that were unaddressed and unresolved via therapy by clear choice or the issues he avoided indulging in therapy will be unavoidable in this trip
    b. James will manifest a 'good time'

4. **A mushroom trip can accomplish the work of years of therapy due to the sheer speed and intensity of the experience.**
    a. **Sense of time is altered and processing of ideas/memories can be far more extensive than in a sober state**
    b. James will dig into introspection, not only because the trip is provoking it, but because he wants to embrace this aspect.
5. Shrooms teach James what he took for granted
    a. Nature
    b. His own home
    c. His friends and dog
        i. Empathy benefit
    d. These realizations parallel his introspective therapy; his sense of connection and feeling grounded in the natural world has a humbling impact on him; his prior grievances pale in comparison to others, the natural process of leaves falling from trees and decomposing into the soil is just like the human life to death cycle. The default network of the brain which is disabled while on shrooms will allow him to cement feelings of being one in nature - and as cringe as it sounds, will feel even more intrinsic to James thereafter.
6. We automatically win when the trip is fun
    a. Beyond therapy - having fun is good - the trip will provoke laughter as he is with his friends

<u>Argument 2: The Post-Trip Implications on James' mentality and actions will always be better than the counterfactual</u>

1. New life intentions
        i. A better conception of himself, particularly post ego-death has high certainty to reduce his anxieties because of his overall self-acceptance on our side of the house speedruns the process that would otherwise go through hurdles and reconsiderations if done in therapy / normal life settings
            1. Youtube motivational videos won't do the trick
        ii. Discovery of passion or curiosity from the trip can provide an external enjoyment in life to James - may be indulging art, learning about history, psychology, etc all become intrinsically interesting to him while before the trip he suffered with lacking motivation
2. Better interpersonal relationships after the fact
    a. He will feel more content and confident in his self-directed approach to life

    b. His connection to his friends at home will be even more close and he will feel more understanding of them - this idea of empathy discovery extends to his treatment and interpretation of others in his life
3. Relationship with Earth
    a. The experience of tripping in the forest where levels of (**chemicals inside of the body** makes emotions far more elastic and significant. Walking on earth barefoot or exploring the trees with your friends. Interactions with animals, etc all will have heightened senses of significance and your appreciation for such will dramatically increase.
        i. The risk of littering or contributing to the destruction of the natural world will be something you're mortified by, and your personal behaviors or ideology on this matter will change.
        ii. This is important because for you the purpose in your life has faltered and your values have plateaued.
        iii. James values nature more - goes on hikes
    b. Animal appreciation
        i. Adopting a dog/cat
            1. Or another animal that is unconventional but is reflection of James sense of empathy and relation to the animal
    c. All of these realizations help him deal with anxiety
4. You likely move away from drugs
    a. While it sounds contrarian many people who try mushrooms end up quitting alcoholism or marijuana addiction because of the heightened sense of consciousness in the trip and after the fact - he may realize his alcoholism/weed consumption burdened him
    b. The ego-death effect which humbles a person into.
    c. Detract from potential additional addictions
        i. Alcoholism or marijuana look less appealing
5. Habit formation
    a. This reduces the burden on therapy which could equate to lowered costs costs or
    b. Productivity

<u>MG spike: Inflection Points are Inherently Good, and Needed right now for James</u>

<u>Overview 1:</u> The Burden of Opp - Not taking shrooms = a loss of opportunity to learn about yourself.

a. You will regret not going on the trip because your friends will perceive your lack of interest as distrust. These are your main friends at home, and not going on the journey with them means you are unlikely to continue that friendship to the same degree with them

<u>Overview 2:</u> Why Reference points are key.

b. A shroom trip is a self-convincing inflection point for growth (life before and after shrooms is a common saying)
c. The realization of his problems and the beauty of aspects of life
d. No matter how good or bad, the intense nature of the trip motivates him to RESEARCH what happened

<u>OV 3: Why Missing Out Sucks</u>

1. Not doing it = a sense of distrust from friends.
    a. They are encouraging you and have reiterated the positive benefits. Your choice not to could change their sense of genuine/authentic connection with you.

<u>RESPONSE 3:</u> FAMILY/FRIENDS - Bringing friend unity and a relationship to home

e. Were the motivations in his college life to be unrealized and his sense of connection to home heightened, the overall sense of anxiety about future prospects is less
f. Why? Because he lives in a generally inexpensive place (small town, etc) with (assuming job openings?) - if he becomes just a hardware store worker and wants to become someone who just does shrooms and stays at home (ie: like his friends) this life can still be good
    i. Any life he was headed towards would be inclusive to stress / pressures /

<u>RESPONSE 1</u> on GOOD TRIP DELUSION - Delusion - or any self-affirming mentality that feels certain - is good.

g. The sense of the trip being a rite of passage as a practice in a culture that doesn't celebrate these activities will make you feel special and self-important, which is good for reinforcing your devotion to the lessons learned on the trip
h. If James chooses a new lifestyle from this experience, he can embark on the experience with more coherent intentions than just 'do business' for study as he was when starting college - this past experience explains his lack of consistent motivation. Our advocacy changes that
i. Why? Let's say he's at home and has a bad trip as opp says, and a component of his realizations relate to his alienation and disgust with home. This mere realization can be a foundational motivator for him to go back to spring semester and lock in to his GPA to pursue his own life. Inversely, if he has a positive affiliation to home, he might become more comfortable with the idea of raising his kids in the suburbs of atlanta, and at minimum, this engagement with his future imagination is the

<u>RESPONSE 2</u> on BAD TRIP: Opps main push is on the 'bad trip' narrative. We mitigate this risk and resolve it if it happens. First:

j. Why? Because a bad trip can still be GOOD FOR HIM
    i. He is Force to reckon with himself
        1. If you buy the opp arguments on a bad trip and that it's deeply scary, at minimum, it recalibrates him. If he has prolonged anxiety and stress, this accelerates his realization of needing to take mental health more seriously. This may look like seeking more counseling, talking with friends, etc. This probably links to better mental health long term as the bad trip was a framework to build up from. In the opp world, all his anxieties and stressors are building up and by junior year, it may be too late and he will have missed the prime chance at an inflection point
    ii. If you buy opps bad trip argument, this probably scares him away from other drugs (especially those that are intense like acid, cocaine, molly, etc)
    iii. James has not properly had any desire to address his problems before - but now he will have the reason to, based on whatever trip experience he has and the lessons he learns from it.
k. Secondly, if the trip is incredibly haunting, the recollection and implications of the trip on James can be a guiding story and framework to

Response 2 - INCREASED ANXIETY

We better alleviate existential dread

c. The boundaries of James' identity dissolve completely—he no longer experiences life as "James," but as pure consciousness. He feels merged with the universe,

nature, or a greater existence, stripping away his usual worries about grades, career, or self-worth.

d. Time feels infinite, and the small anxieties of life seem irrelevant compared to the vast, interconnected reality he's experiencing.
e. How This Alleviates Existential Dread: When the trip ends, James returns to himself but with a new perspective, realizing that many of his previous fears were self-imposed and unnecessary.
f. Existence feels lighter, freer, and less daunting—he understands that he is part of something much bigger.
g. Death feels less scary—many people say that experiencing ego death reduces their fear of mortality because they feel connected to something eternal.

<u>SPIKE:</u> Shifting away from other substances

l. In the status quo, he smokes and drinks a lot - because these substances are momentary enjoyment and recreation, his reason for using it likely overlaps with underlying stressors and anxieties. On our side of the house, we can break that cycle of dependence or positive affiliations by introducing a new substance that cannot be done every day, but has to be (at most) every month, and is undeniably more impactful.
m. James probably re-evaluates his interest in weed and alcohol because hyper consciousness he gains from the shrooms teaches him that with weed or alcohol the main implication is slower and weaker thinking - a bigger damager of the brain - consequently, he's better suited to rationalize his swift away from weed when on the opp side he must quit with no alternative, and he becomes more susceptible to stagnation and relapse.
n. This means 3 things
    i. If he loves mushrooms and wants to do it again, he must adopt a patient mentality and prepare for future trips with clarified intentions and an understanding of the ideal set and setting. So if he does again, it a) replaces the propensity of other substances and b) teaches him to engage with the substance more positively and c) he probably finds a community in mushroom culture, whether online or in person, to discuss his experiences with others. This is better than other sub-groups that may unite through alcohol or weed.
    ii. So even if you buy a 'bad trip' argument from opp, he can at least access those with shared stories or experiences which can help him forge new friendships. These friendships are likely to be better friendships than those dependent on weed or alcohol. Why? Alcohol and weed can be every weekday or weekend, while shrooms are once a month.

iii. His investment in the shrooms community will provide him active narratives to move away from substances like marijuana and weed because the shroom movement is characterized by its therapeutic aspects rather than momentary enjoyment of recreational use that is innate to substances like weed or alcohol. And Because shrooms can't be consistently consumed, the recreational use of it must be respected as more of a ritual than a daily habit. Risks of overuse after the trip is low in likelihood, especially as he has obligations at college.

o. On the counterfactual, his use of substances prolongs and he lacks any incentive to shift away. There is no inflection point to refer to on their side.

A2 legality:

- NUQ, you clearly aren't that upset about the whole thing bc he does weed and drinks
- No consequences
- Not universalizable principle

Responses and Collapse (Gov)

Collapse/Ballots

1.

Defense to opp

1. If their parents allow him to stay at home and not have a job, it probably means they unconditionally love him
2. Doing it at another time is too late
    - It would be expensive to do it in a formalized setting (ie: Ayahuasca type therapy trips)
3. Microdosing Mushrooms could be better

Quicky - whats the best the MO got

1. Oh, studies aren't like James. Judge, gut check / differentiation

Shrooms as illegal

- There is no legal risk - gut check this because people do it often
- Dude obviously weed has more stigma (PEOPLE SMELL IT IN PUBLIC TOO)
- Also he is in his house with friends who are currently not in prison and did it all year

"He will feel guilt"

- **Then hell go to therapy lol**
- **Or if not therapy, he might just really care to talk to someone else from reddit who also had a bad trip. He will find other people in this community if he so chooses. We give him a better realization of options after the trip, in Opp, he is stagnant and headed towards a dissatisfactory career in business (if he graduates at all)**

Friends incapacitated

1. Friends are more tolerant than you
2. What if you overdose / keep you grounded
    a. **Dogs and friends are grounding (better than family)**
    b. **Nature is grounding and inherently calming**
    c. **If some emergency comes about - this only speedruns the therapy forcing mechanism**

Move to ballots

Exacerbates other issues because bad trip - they sight anxiety based on environment

1. Serotonin levels vary and the default network is turned off, the elasticity here means if he experiences moments of a bad trip his friends can save him from it by moving him to new environments or stimuli like different music he likes. Remember, James will be very meticulous about accommodating a THERAPUTIC - not inherently good or bad

The rest they got is defense (no impact)

1. You should weigh risk of **fixing his life vs one bad trip**
2. Judge we impact lol - lets do this now

<u>NOW ONTO BALLOTS</u>

At the top level, we are the only chance of solvency. We don't say that shrooms alone solves anxiety or your entire life, we're saying that doing therapy in good faith can and that stopping using weed and alchohol can

This is probably the best chance you got at shrooms in college. Its a safe space, with your dog, and its not at 3.5 grams

1. Counterfactual, not doing it is worse than Opps best case scenario for them
    a. Opps absolute best case is that you use shrooms every 3 weeks but not in the best way
    b. CFactual IS USING ALCHOHOL EVERY DAY
        i. Shrooms cannot and why no dependence
        ii. Recognize that even if we buy their best case that the shroom trip is bad, the counterfactual is FAR MORE BAD trips with weed or alchohol
    c. They concede this is worse because it does not just suppress your feelings but rather forces you to think about them in a different way
    d. But another important concession is how you have a different social life which will be better

Give time to directly respond to their ballot

2. James is a good manager of his trip experience - the trip will be good
    a. He's done the research - he feels a positive
    b. He's in a home environment (we already explained a good trip)
    c. He has wanted to have this experience under its relationship to therapeutic benefits - he is certain to take lessons away from the trip.
    d. Even bad trip is good…because he goes into the trip wanting a theraputic/enlightening experience (hes looking for it)

General After experience

    e. James personally (empathy to family)
    f. James taking best advantage of therapy - he now has a framework

g. James new friends
    i. New community (shrooms and away from weed communities)

Alleviates existential dread

Judge, i know it sounds like we fiat a good time. Pretty clear why thats the case, but if you take their worst world…

Their ballots

1. Guilt and christianity
    a. Dropped sarah's response that you reconnect with religion and can get more connected with your parents, reconnecting to their religion outweighs a shorterm guilt

What we heard from <u>OPP</u>

- Family disappointed
- Estranged from his own culture
    - **We TURN this THIS FAR BETTER**
    - **(If) Disatisfied with norms of parents *(relation to SPIRITUALITY!!!!!)***
    -

: Drug makes him more unstable and he becomes TOLERANT TO IT

- **Not the case**

THIS IS Their worst world - bad trip

1. Uncertainty
    a. 2 grams avoids the worst
    b. Friends have good intentions
    c. He has his own intentions
2. Dependent
    a. Doesn't happen - if hes shrooms over weed, fine
    b. In **their world, he is dependent on weed/alcohol more and those ruin his brain on the daily.**

Tight block

1. Illegality
    a. Perceived risk of real trouble
    b. Getting in real trouble
2. Friends as provocateurs of a bad time
    a. Coming home will make this person feel unaccomplished
3. Doing it again - becoming shroom-brained
    a. Job opportunities
    b. Life choices isolate you to a more narrow group
4. Too much intention negatively impacts the trip - why?
5. Psychosis risk
6. Bad trip
    a. Scary
    b. Realizing problems about yourself
    c. Anxiety = susceptible
7. Delusion is bad
    a. Perception of habit development etc
    b. Ability to navigate therapy (CBT) could be reduced because of you are convinced of many of your own realizations and thoughts
8. Reckless experimentation
9. Relationship with parents
10. Worsened relationship with peers
    a. The altered perspective can change one's approach to their friends
11. Feeling paralyzed

12. Friends misread the vibe
    a. The novelty of the trip to you but not them means they cannot properly feel ‘on your level’
    b. And you won’t feel like they are. Their happiness could have you feeling even more left out
    c. Also friends within their own trip, rather than being ‘trip setters’ worsens risk of them badly managing your own bad experience
13. Delusion is bad
    a.

    -

    -